naysayers, I began making plans to join the Yatra in Nanded the day it entered Maharashtra.

The next, admittedly tougher, hurdle was my family, especially my mother. She was mortified at my decision. ‘Rahul Gandhi?’ she asked in disbelief when I first brought it up. ‘Really? You know what happened with Indira ji? And with Rajiv Gandhi? The Gandhi family has a history of dangerous deaths. Are you really sure you want to walk right into a security risk?’ Over the next few days, she tried her best to discourage me. Her desperate entreaties did not fall on deaf ears. I must confess that these thoughts gnawed at the back of my mind. But I kept reminding myself that the risk I would be taking was nothing in comparison to what Rahul and his compatriots were taking in walking across the length of India, with a security cover that was unimpressive and lacklustre.

And so I announced my intentions to join the Bharat Jodo Yatra on my social media pages. Backing out from it now was not possible. Meanwhile, I followed Rahul’s walk towards Maharashtra with astonishment. Despite what we were all seeing on social media, the mainstream media was as mute as a graveyard. The media offered little to no coverage of the Yatra and were busy beaming the randomest topics that did not concern people in the least.

But social media was on fire. The support BJY was getting from all quarters was astounding. People I knew were not hostile to the Congress were sharing videos of the Yatra. It had clearly ignited conversations across chai shops and dinner tables. No matter how hard the media tried, there was a certain euphoria among the masses. And that was only magnified by stories coming from the common people who had witnessed the Yatra. They were genuinely heart-warming.

On the eve of my journey towards Nanded, I got a call from my friend, Tabu Rao, the wife of a senior Congress leader from Karnataka. She wanted to know if I was really going to be there for the Yatra and if I would like to walk beside Rahul Gandhi. Pleasantly surprised but secretly happy, there was no way I was going to refuse this chance. And so she quickly connected me to Byju KB, who was Rahul’s man Friday. Byju earnestly assured me